While turning down bad roles in pictures, I had several options to support the family.

I still couldn’t sing or dance, but, with Nancy in the audience every night, I did a nightclub floor show at the Last Frontier Hotel in Las Vegas for two weeks, in which I was an emcee for a group called the Continentals. The audience’s reaction was good, the reviews were good, the pay was terrific, and they invited me to come back. But Nancy and I missed our life in California and neither of us thought much of smoke-filled nightclubs, so when the two weeks ended we were glad to go home.

I could have gotten a job on Broadway, which was always looking for Hollywood actors, but Nancy and I were devoted Californians and not interested in a long-term relationship with New York.

There were many offers to star in a television series, but I was firmly against it.

I was sure a television series could be a professional kiss of death to a movie actor: The people who owned movie theaters thought nobody would buy a ticket to see someone they could see at home in their living room for nothing. Besides, most television series expired after two or three years, and from then on, audiences—and producers—tended to think of you only as the character you’d played in the TV series.

In the end, television guest spots not only tided us over financially but led me to one of those unexpected and unplanned turns in the road—the kind that can take you a long way from where you thought you were going.